Inspection of Essex local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 21 to 25 September 2026

Lead inspector: Catherine Heron, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	**Grade**
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of children in care	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Outstanding

Children, young people and families continue to receive high-quality support and services from Essex local authority children's services that make a significant positive difference to their lives. Areas of excellent practice have been sustained, others have been enhanced and areas for improvement from the previous inspection have been addressed. The well-established director of children's services (DCS) and leadership team, supported by strong corporate and political support, have successfully steered the service through significant times of change, while remaining child and family centred.

Significant investment in early help and targeted services continues to support children to receive the right help at the right time, avoiding the need for statutory services. Prioritising the reunification and kinship strategy, alongside the successful creation of new homes for children, has strengthened the council's sufficiency arrangements. The voice of children and young people continually shapes and influences wider development services for the future.

The stable, established and skilled workforce builds trusted authentic relationships with children and families to fully understand their experiences and nurture positive change. Leaders know themselves well and have in-depth analysis of the service's strengths and challenges in the context of changing communities.

What needs to improve?[1]

- Joint working between the young carer service and children's social workers to create comprehensive plans (outcome 1, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: outstanding

1. The strong early help offer is well established in Essex. Children and their families benefit from an impressive wide range of locally based early help services. The family solutions multi-agency service provides intensive targeted family help to children and families with multiple needs. A new pilot assessment provides a strong and coherent structure to assessment activity, which ensures that children's assessments are detailed, analytical and informed by direct work with children. Cultural genograms are used to explore family history and identify support and safety within the child's network. This results in children's plans that are clear and deliver support that helps children's situations improve. Children's changing needs are well recognised, and support is provided seamlessly across social work and family help to ensure children receive the right level of help.

2. Contacts and referrals initial screening is timely, carried out by highly experienced and skilled workers. Managers' first-touch oversight provides clear guidance to workers, followed by regular reviews thereafter. Workers consistently engage with parents at early stages to help them understand worries and ideas on what may help. Workers use this information to determine the depth of enquiries and decisions. Workers are professionally curious; they make thorough enquiries, consider history and previous interventions and recognise a range of harms and needs. Partnership working in the front door hub is strong. Management oversight is robust, reflecting purposeful and reflective decisions that are proportionate and family focused. The impact of this well-thought-out decision-making is that repeat requests for help are low in Essex because families receive the right help when they need it.

3. The emergency duty service provides timely and robust out-of-hours support to children and their families. Safeguarding concerns about children are well managed, and interim safety planning reduces risk. Excellent communication between out-of-hours and day-time teams ensures that follow-up action is timely and child centred.

4. Children's lived experiences are well understood. Assessments, including those for disabled children and for unborn babies, are thorough, include multi-agency information and consider children's ethnicity, culture, family norms and

[1] The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the Children's Social Care: National Framework. This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

transitions. Pre-birth assessments are completed early and inform effective planning for babies at birth. Workers are professionally curious and strongly follow the relational practice model, being honest with parents and leading courageous conversations about hidden issues and trauma. As a result, parents are supported rather than judged and empowered to work in partnership with children's social workers to identify solutions and engage meaningfully in change work.

5. Direct work with children, including disabled children, continues to be a strength. Children are seen and heard. Unannounced visits increase workers' perspectives of children's daily lives. This helps to ensure that interventions are firmly centred on children's experiences, views, wishes and feelings. The excellent quality of relationships that children and their parents have with their workers means workers know children very well and recognise subtle behavioural changes in children and their parents. Workers are alert to parental disguised compliance, and they take decisive action when parental cooperation and engagement decline by escalating children's cases appropriately.

6. When safeguarding concerns are identified, children receive a strong multi-agency response. Child protection strategy meetings are timely and reach appropriate decisions for children. Subsequent child protection enquiries thoroughly consider presenting issues and history. Joint working with police is strong because there is a shared understanding of issues to explore and action to safeguard children. In highly complex circumstances, review strategy meetings track changing risk and review the progress of safety planning well. This helps to ensure that children are safeguarded effectively.

7. Initial child protection conferences are convened quickly when there are concerns that children are at risk. Decision-making at conferences and core group meetings is underpinned by strong participation from professionals and family and careful consideration of risks and protective factors. 'Child only' conferences are separate meetings for children and their conference chair prior to the main meeting. This ensures that children's views are clearly understood and then can be shared with the wider conference group. Records of meetings show clear rationale for recommendations. Conference chairs provide excellent oversight between reviews, which ensures that decisions and plans are child centred and on track.

8. Children's child in need plans are solution focused, detailed and outcome specific, based on realistic goals. Family networks engage in meetings where key issues are transparently discussed so that individuals are part of the child's plan and understand their role. This creates a shared understanding of need and risk and enables children's networks to act quickly when they are concerned about the children's welfare. Plans develop over time and do not end prematurely. For complex situations, social workers consult with child-in-need reviewing officers, who provide additional guidance and lead meetings with the child's network. This oversight monitors progress objectively and poses effective challenge that keeps the planning sharply focused on children.

9. The response to domestic abuse, neglect and other types of harm is effective. Workers recognise barriers that impact on parental factors and progress, so they adapt parenting intervention and resources to suit parents' needs, while remaining focused on the impact for children. Since the last inspection, leaders have significantly invested in creating more multidisciplinary teams (MDTs) for children in need, including those in need of protection. MDTs deliver purposeful, well-coordinated child and adult interventions that focus clearly on reducing risk. Practice is strengths-based, offering a range of services to families, such as domestic abuse perpetrator programmes and adult mental health support, that enable parents to make sustained change and make a difference to children's lives.

10. Pre-proceedings work is meaningfully diverting families away from family courts and improving children's situations. Investment in court progression officers is a contributing factor in improving court timeliness for those children's cases that move to care proceedings. Letters to parents before proceedings clearly set out concerns for families and what parents need to do to avoid going to court. Simplified guidance, using images and icons, red, amber, green (RAG) rating and photographs, supports parents who have additional communication needs. Families are supported to access family group decision-making.

11. Children who go missing from home receive a prompt multi-agency response. Workers talk to children about missing episodes during 'missing chats' to understand children's experiences and risks. Information obtained contributes to tailored missing prevention plans that help to reduce risk. Children benefit from targeted intervention, such as the in-house 'Choices Group', where children learn about dangers and explore the reasons why they may go missing. This has had a positive impact in reducing missing episodes for many children. Where there are concerns that children are at risk of radicalisation or exploitation, children receive a strong multi-agency response from the risk in the community team, which acts quickly in response to concerns. Strengths-based work with parents helps to increase their capacity to understand and manage risks to protect their children.

12. The young carers service is well established and has strengthened since the last inspection. The previous 12 months of awareness-raising and outreach has identified over 1,500 children as young carers. Children benefit from a wide range of support and activities to make friends and have fun. Leaders have improved accessible data quality, which has increased their line of sight and ability to identify population changes, themes and trends in accessing services. An enhanced triage system has also significantly reduced waiting times for assessment. Assessments reflect children's caring roles, and support plans are developed in line with these. However, for those children with child in need plans, caring responsibilities do not feature strongly enough. Information-sharing between young carer practitioners and social workers can be disjointed, which impacts on the quality of the young carers' plans and workers' awareness of children's experiences.

13. Essex's private fostering service continues to be very proactive in raising awareness and reaching a wide range of services and agencies. Children receive an excellent service. They are seen often and take part in reviews with their carers and other household members. Assessments and reviews are comprehensive, and safeguarding checks are routinely completed to inform analysis of risk. Leadership in this area is strong and engages regionally to share good practice.

14. Children aged 16-17 who present as homeless receive a swift and responsive service. Workers ensure that children's whereabouts are known and that they have safe interim housing arrangements. Preventative work helps children to be identified before they are homeless and rebuild strained family relationships. Workers listen carefully to children's views and respond well when there are safeguarding concerns. Children receive information, although not all children are informed of the local authority advocacy service. The impact of preventative work is that few children need to go into care, but when they do, arrangements are made quickly.

15. The local authority designated officer service is strong and responds effectively to allegations against people working with children and vulnerable adults. Allegations are carefully screened and managed through well-coordinated multi-agency decision-making. Information-sharing is robust, and the wellbeing of children is paramount.

16. Leaders and managers have effective arrangements to identify, track and support children missing education and those educated through elective home education. Robust checks confirm children's whereabouts. Clear processes ensure that information gathered about children's vulnerabilities and risk is appropriately shared with children's social care. Leaders recognise that new legislation and increasing demand in this part of the service is stretching capacity, and they have credible plans to address this.

The experiences and progress of children in care: outstanding

17. When it is in children's best interests, they move into care. These life-changing decisions are based on rigorous assessments of risk and include appropriate senior management oversight and scrutiny. Most children experience moves that are well coordinated and carefully planned. Records of management decisions and actions for care planning are well documented in children's records.

18. When choosing the right home for children, workers firstly explore options within children's families. Family group conferences are routinely held to identify potential connected carers and family supports. Investment in the kinship team has increased capacity to enhance awareness of kinship across the workforce, improved timeliness and quality of assessments and the support offer to approved kinship carers. Children's social workers work closely with assessing social workers in the kinship team, and potential kinship carers are

kept well informed during the assessment process. Kinship carers understand their rights and responsibilities and legal options for children's permanence. After legal orders are granted, ongoing support is a strength. The kinship team helps carers respond to children's changing needs by providing support that increases resilience, supports enduring relationships and sustains children's care arrangements.

19. Most children, including disabled children, live in foster care within or near to Essex, where they thrive. Children told inspectors they did not feel the stigma often attributed to being in care and described their own experiences as positive and rewarding.

20. The importance of children maintaining and developing safe family connections is strongly understood and supported by the family time service. Workers actively promote relationships that matter to children and make purposeful attempts to restore relationships that are strained. This helps children to maintain lifelong relationships.

21. Children are helped to return to their families' care when it is safe to do so with appropriate support. Decisions for reunification are based on thorough assessments and appropriate checks, alongside robust senior management oversight and approval. The connecting and uniting team provides highly effective support to progress these plans. Workers foster excellent relationships with families and carry out preparation and phased transition planning that helps children and their family members prepare for the move. Workers have the time to spend with children, carrying out direct work so children understand reasons for moves and their life story. The quality of this support means the majority of children experience smooth transitions and parents are well prepared to resume care. This increases the chances of children remaining safely within their family.

22. Children influence their own individual plans. Plans, known as 'life plans', are totally child centred and of excellent quality. They are typically written by children in the first person and feature family pictures and brief life-story segments, comprehensively detailing children's needs and actions. Plan reviews are mostly timely, well attended and coordinated by independent reviewing officers (IROs) who know children well. IROs monitor children's plans between formal reviews and advocate effectively on behalf of children to support their progress and address any delays.

23. The voice of children and young people influences service design. Children in care and care-leaver groups are welcomed to a range of platforms to share their views, such as leading keynote speeches in conferences, writing published books and attending regular steering groups with elected members. Service-led research into the experiences of specific cohorts of children also captures their voice and experiences, for example understanding children's perspectives of having a deprivation of liberty order.

24. Children benefit from strong relationships with their social workers, who know them well and visit them regularly. Workers advocate strongly for children to receive the right support. Workforce stability means that many children have consistent workers for long periods and consequently have trusting relationships with them. Direct work is purposeful, creative and attuned to children's individual needs. Workers use observations, activities and play to explore children's views and understand their experiences. Life-story books are sensitively written and thoughtfully planned. This effective work helps children understand their histories, the reasons why they came into care and the decisions made about their futures. Timely completion of these books is adversely affected by staff pressures within the children in care teams. Leaders have fully recognised this, with plans to increase worker capacity. The independent visitor scheme provides many children with enduring relationships, some for as long as 10 years. As a result, children feel valued and connected.

25. Children's physical and mental health needs are well understood and supported. Children's emotional wellbeing is supported through accessible mental health workers and clinical support from the MDT teams. This specialist support helps ensure that children's emotional wellbeing and mental health is a central element of care planning. Leaders are addressing delays in children receiving initial health assessments when they first come into care. However, carers and social workers ensure that children get health support when they need it.

26. Children are encouraged and supported to achieve their educational aspirations and enjoy positive experiences. The virtual school is ambitious for children in care and fulfils its corporate parenting responsibilities effectively. The quality of personal education plans has improved since the last inspection, and these plans contain clear, specific targets and strong evidence of children's views, aspirations and support needs. Carers contribute meaningfully to planning. This supports children to make progress from their starting points. Children's achievements are celebrated. The annual 'It's My Life' event champions children in care, with access to mentors and a range of activities, and children have fun. These opportunities help children to build confidence and develop soft skills that contribute to their development and sense of achievement.

27. Safeguarding and responses to children at risk of exploitation are effective. Children's vulnerabilities, including those living in supported accommodation, are well understood and direct work is targeted at relevant issues, such as harmful relationships and substance misuse. When children in care go missing, return home interviews help children and workers understand the reasons for them going missing and develop plans to reduce risks.

28. Sufficiency of homes for children remains an ongoing challenge. The use of unlawful unregistered settings has reduced since the last inspection, but a very small minority of children do still live in such homes when searches for suitable alternatives have been exhausted. Most children who have lived in these unlawful homes have stayed there for short periods of time. At the time of this inspection, a very small number of older children were living in unregistered

children's homes. These children receive regular and often increased weekly visiting by their social workers and other professionals. Searches for registered alternatives continue, and when these are identified, children move quickly. Leaders actively encourage registration with Ofsted and monitor the progress of registration applications. The quality assurance team carries out thorough initial health and safety assessment visits in the absence of regulatory oversight. These identify relevant actions relating to the home environment or safeguarding arrangements that providers are required to address. Actions are tracked well through weekly care coordination meetings. For a few older children in longer-term unregistered arrangements, quality assurance could be even further strengthened, which leaders recognise.

29. Separated migrant children receive a warm welcome in the newly opened children's hub. Children are well supported by workers who understand children's unique safeguarding and cultural needs and the impact of trauma. Children's range of needs are well met so they have suitable accommodation, healthcare, financial support and education opportunities. Legal advice is appropriately sought to help children achieve legal stability. This is an area of practice that has improved since the last inspection.

30. The fostering service is child focused and is growing to respond to the changing needs of children. The in-house Oasis fostering community provides enhanced therapeutic support, peer connections and practical assistance in addition to the intensive fostering scheme, which contributes effectively to children's placement stability. Strong, stable and child-centred leadership has created a positive culture where staff and carers feel valued, supported and empowered, which is contributing to improved outcomes for children.

31. Permanence planning commences when children move into care, and all permanence options are considered, including early permanence. While court delays have affected permanence planning for some children, overall timeliness of care proceedings has improved. Leaders have engaged with the courts to address this issue and ensure that managers have clear oversight of children's plans so that children do not experience avoidable delay.

32. Children are helped to prepare for adulthood with a wide range of targeted support, including fostering outreach and child and family support workers. A range of housing options are carefully considered, including registered supported accommodation, in advance of children leaving care so that their accommodation transitions are managed well. Close attention is given to the level of support children will require when they reach 18 years old so that children have the necessary support in early adulthood.

33. A significant number of children who cannot return home are successfully adopted. Assessments, family finding and support to adopters are effective. Feedback from adopters, staff and partners was overwhelmingly positive, reflecting a service that is ambitious, reflective and committed to achieving positive outcomes for children and families. Decision-making for these children

is timely and well evidenced, but some children are affected by shortages in suitable adopters. Leaders' sufficiency strategy recognises the challenge in available placements for children.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: outstanding

34. Care leavers services continue to be a strength in Essex. Care leavers receive excellent support from dedicated personal advisers (PAs) who provide meaningful and nurturing support. PAs work closely with young people's social workers, ensuring young people's smooth transitions into the leaving care service. PAs know their young people very well and are aspirational for them to do well and live fulfilling lives. PAs make visits in line with the young people's needs and maintain contact between visits to support young people to be safe and well. Care leavers who spoke with inspectors were universally positive about the quality of their relationships with PAs and the level of practical and emotional support they receive, valuing this as a tangible example of co-parenting.

35. Care leavers understand their rights and entitlements. PAs have a good understanding of the comprehensive and wide-ranging local offer, so they guide and remind young people to access the offer according to their needs and wishes.

36. Care leavers are helped to access support to address their physical and mental health and wellbeing. PAs accompany young people to appointments when needed and are well attuned to young people's emotional states and stressors and gradually help them to recognise their triggers. The council has invested in a dedicated mental health service for care leavers, which provides consultation, assessment, therapeutic intervention and training.

37. The quality of support to separated migrant care leavers has improved since the last inspection. PAs demonstrate an understanding of young people's arduous journeys to the UK and document their experiences clearly. Young people benefit from attending the separated migrant children and young people hub and access a range of support, such as navigating legal applications and appeals. PAs' practical advocacy fosters trust and builds meaningful relationships with young people, which is reflected in the regular contact between them. Young people are supported to develop community networks and connect to social and worship groups, in addition to contacting family overseas, where possible. This improved support helps young people develop enduring relationships that build young people's resilience and self-esteem.

38. Pathway plans are co-produced, personalised and are of consistently high quality, reflecting individual needs and goals. Those that are written in the first person reflect strong ownership and investment in the plan. Plans are easy to follow and regularly updated, and actions are SMART (specific, measurable, attainable, relevant and time-based) and targeted on young people's important

priorities. PAs are aspirational for young people and actively support them in their life goals, including employment or training.

39. Most care leavers live in accommodation that is suitable and meets their needs. Some young people benefit from continuing to live with their former foster carers via 'staying put' arrangements. This provides young people with stability and continued connections. The strong commissioned supported accommodation offer supports young people to have stable homes.

40. Care leavers reconnect to family members with intensive support from commissioned services and the local authority's divisional base intervention teams. This intervention sensitively supports young people to reunify with family. Most PAs have an in-depth understanding of young people's family networks and sensitively engage in relational work between young people and their families.

41. When concerns about risks to care leavers arise, young people receive multi-agency targeted support to increase safety and wellbeing. Where there are safety concerns for care leavers in relation to domestic abuse, PAs proactively share information with the multi-agency risk assessment conference to influence protection and planning.

42. A growing proportion of care leavers are successfully participating in education, employment or training, and these opportunities are improving. Dedicated youth and employability advisers provide targeted support, helping young people to access a range of opportunities and overcome barriers that impact on them achieving their goals. Leaders continue to advocate for care leavers through Essex's care leaver pledge and have strengthened the council's partnership with employers, creating more opportunities for young people to engage in work and apprenticeships and move into sustainable employment. The launch of 'The Unseen', a short film challenging negative perceptions and stereotypes about care leavers and the art exhibition, has given care leavers other platforms to express themselves and help others understand their lived experience.

43. Care leavers who are parents receive a strong, compassionate response and emotional and practical support from their PAs, who act as good co-grandparents. PAs act as a trusted adult who young people rely on for advice, equipping young people to make informed child-centred decisions. Young people benefit from attending the 'care leavers parents programme' and other parenting groups in their local communities, where they strengthen parenting skills and spend time with other parents and children. PAs help young people to access support from children's social care when necessary.

44. Care leavers in custody receive purposeful, consistent support from their PAs, who maintain regular contact and work with other agencies to help meet young people's needs. PAs plan well for young people's release, considering more than housing needs and listening to young people's views. PAs engage with young

people's family network, providing information and emotional support that helps young people to maintain contact and sustain lifelong relationships that increase their resilience upon release.

45. Care leavers are actively supported by PAs up to the age of 25. Decisions about ending support are individualised and made in consultation with care leavers according to their wishes. Discussions with young people as they approach 21 years old include information about continued support and how to seek help if needed.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: outstanding

46. Since the last inspection in 2023, leaders have remained ambitious and have sustained high-quality services to vulnerable children and families in Essex. The long-serving DCS has cultivated a purposeful service-wide leadership team that is progressive, highly skilled and child centred. Leaders have shown resilience and a resolute approach to significant local and national reforms that have required resource and strategic planning. Increased leadership capacity has ensured effective oversight and readiness for this journey.

47. Corporate and council support has been relentless and continues to provide children's services with a solid foundation to deliver impactful services. During council leadership changes, leaders have showcased children's services key priorities and influenced corporate decision-making. The well-embedded governance arrangements ensure that executive and elected members hold leaders to account.

48. Essex children's social care is a learning organisation and works collaboratively with others. Participation opportunities ensure children, their families and carers are understood, and their wishes, feelings and ambitions are also at the core of practice. Leaders embrace scrutiny and challenge from external agencies; they have responded effectively to previous inspection findings, and they remain active members in sector-led improvement.

49. Corporate parenting responsibilities are prioritised and evaluated through the well-established co-parenting board, with views of children and young people and involvement from partners, councillors and the senior leadership team. The voice of children and young people is strong. Significant investment and sustained high-quality preventative and statutory services are helping children to remain at home living with their family where it is safe to do so. Further investment in sufficiency has increased the number of suitable homes for children and young people when they need to live in care. Two more Essex-owned children's homes have registered, and investment has increased in foster care and adoption recruitment and kinship care and reunification teams. This has made a difference to the progress of children's plans and contributed to the significant reduction in the use of unregistered children's homes. Leaders

know that there is more to do in this space to ensure that children and care leavers have good-quality homes.

50. Leaders have well-established, mature and cohesive partnerships with police, schools, Cafcass, the family courts and the integrated care board. The partnership relationships are mature, and the strong culture of collaboration ensures clearly defined multi-agency priorities, action and learning from serious incidents.

51. Leaders have a comprehensive, highly effective performance management system and quality assurance framework that accurately provide strong insights into children's services. Consequently, leaders have consistent and highly effective oversight across the service which informs their evidence-based self-assessment. Technology systems are developing to support practice and improve the quality of children's records. Leaders' analysis of evolving community needs informs strategic planning and financial investment so that services remain relevant, responsive and are continually developed.

52. Essex's 'conditions for success' and relational practice model shine across through the service and set high expectations for practice. The strong professional development offer from the social care academy is firmly established and delivers high-quality training and workshops to workers that align with current areas of practice improvement. The wide range of development opportunities equips workers with knowledge and guidance and empowers them in their work with children and families.

53. Workers' caseloads are manageable. Leaders know where capacity challenges exist and provide strategic and operational responses to alleviate pressures. Effective working relationships across the teams and their collective ambition to build an even better service are palpable. Change is managed very well. Leaders thoughtfully trial and test service change to identify what works, acquire feedback and reduce risk before full implementation, which includes input from academic analysis to inform decisions, for example on areas such as fostering and population trends, needs and vulnerabilities. Workers therefore have strong confidence in their leaders and describe them as visible, approachable and leading by example.

54. Management oversight of practice is regular, reflective and influences progress on children and young people's plans. Workers' personal and group supervision creates a reflective space to hypothesise and plan. Workers report having very positive experiences of supervision, although supervision records do not always capture the level of reflection and oversight provided during sessions.

55. Workers are well supported and say they feel valued. Anti-racist practice is a strength, and this policy is being embedded across the service and places value on inclusivity for all. Workforce stability and retention is excellent and results in a strong system of consistent practice for children and families. The vast majority of workers have been employed in the service for long periods and

many for their entire career, which brings extensive experience to practice and knowledge about the communities they serve. Workers across the service meaningfully engage with children and families. They build positive relationships through child-centred practice that nurtures progress and creates sustainable change.

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